Annexation (Manifest Destiny)

John L. O'Sullivan · United States Magazine and Democratic Review · July–August 1845

Source: John L. O'Sullivan, 'Annexation,' United States Magazine and Democratic Review (July–Aug. 1845), text via Teaching American History. Public domain.

Editor John L. O'Sullivan coined the phrase 'manifest destiny' in this essay arguing for the annexation of Texas. The phrase captured a popular belief that the United States was providentially destined to expand across the continent — a belief used to justify the Mexican-American War, the displacement of Native peoples, and the expansion (or restriction) of slavery into new territories.

Connect: The Missouri Compromise (Class 8) tried to freeze the slavery question by geographic line. How does westward expansion re-open that wound?

Key Passages

The famous phrase

> other nations have undertaken to intrude themselves into it, between us and the proper parties to the case … for the avowed object of thwarting our policy and hampering our power, limiting our greatness and checking the fulfillment of our manifest destiny to overspread the continent allotted by Providence for the free development of our yearly multiplying millions.

On California

> California will, probably, next fall away from the loose adhesion which, in such a country as Mexico, holds a remote province in a slight equivocal kind of dependence on the metropolis. … Imbecile and distracted, Mexico never can exert any real governmental authority over such a country.

On race and 'progress'

> The Anglo-Saxon foot is already on its borders. Already the advance guard of the irresistible army of Anglo-Saxon emigration has begun to pour down upon it, armed with the plow and the rifle, and marking its trail with schools and colleges, courts and representative halls, mills and meeting-houses.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Debate over annexing Texas (annexed 1845), the Oregon boundary dispute with Britain, and growing tensions with Mexico on the eve of the Mexican-American War.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Readers of the Democratic Review, mostly Democrats and supporters of expansion, and the wider reading public.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	John L. O'Sullivan, a Democratic editor and nationalist who saw American expansion as God's plan; Mexican and Native views are absent.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ: Identify ONE specific U.S. policy that translated the rhetoric of ‘manifest destiny’ into action between 1845 and 1860.
2. How does O’Sullivan’s racial framing shape the argument? What groups does it exclude?
3. Why did this phrase, coined in a magazine essay, become so politically powerful?